

The Breath Beneath the Vaults

My name is Élise V. I am thirty-four years old, and I restore antique books for an antiquarian, a profession that has taught me to love broken things without trying to make them perfect. I never believed in the stories people tell at night to frighten themselves. Not until that winter of 2009, when my sister stopped writing me letters that ended with a joke, and I went looking for her in the mountains south of Sibiu, in Transylvania.

What I am telling here, I lived through. I do not claim to have understood it.

I had taken the train to Sighișoara, then a bus that climbed into the hills, and finally walked for two hours along a path the snow had almost erased. On the bus, I had been told about an abandoned fortified church that had stood empty for decades—one of countless Saxon churches deserted along with their villages. Members of a discreet circle—called *Ordo Draconis Rubri*, or the Order of the Red Dragon—were said to meet there, although no one had ever explained exactly what was meant by “discreet.”

I had come looking for my sister.

Mathilde had disappeared from our lives long before she disappeared for good. First, the letters had grown less frequent, then their tone had changed. *I have found something that passes through me*, she had written in her last letter, posted from Brașov. *I don't know how to explain it to you without making you think I've lost my mind. Maybe I have. Maybe that's just fine.*

You don't forget a sentence like that.

The church stood at the top of the path, its cracked defensive tower and gray stone walls crowned by a half-collapsed battlement walk—the characteristic architecture of those fortified sanctuaries that had once protected Saxon villages from invasion. Inside, the original frescoes, nearly a thousand years old in places, were fading beneath the damp, leaving only ghostly silhouettes upon the walls. The air smelled of melted wax and something sharper, metallic.

A man greeted me at the entrance to the narthex—small, bearded, his face weathered by the cold, dressed in a simple black *exorasson* that vaguely resembled the robes of Orthodox monks without quite being one. He must have been in his forties, though something in his gaze—a particular stillness, almost mineral in quality—made him seem older at first glance, then younger the moment after. His voice, when he spoke, was gentle. Almost too gentle, the kind of calm found only in those who have nothing left to lose, or who have learned to pretend otherwise.

“*You're looking for Mathilde*,” he said in perfect French, without my having given him her name. “*She told us about you. A sister who doubts everything.*”

He wasn't lying.

I was allowed into the nave. The original pews were gone, replaced by an empty space in which a circle had been drawn in chalk upon the worn flagstones. At the back, on the wall, a copper object caught the scant light filtering through the shattered stained-glass windows—a winged shape that gave the absurd and persistent impression of breathing.

I will not recount what I saw that night with the precision of a report. There were candles, arranged so that no corner of the room was ever entirely lit or entirely dark. There were voices, low and murmuring, a vibration that seemed to come less from throats than from the stones themselves, as though the entire building had retained the memory of older songs.

And there was Mathilde.

She stood near the altar, her eyes closed, her face turned upward. When she opened her eyes and found me in the darkness, she did not startle. She smiled, with a smile that was too wide, too slow.

“*You came*,” she said. “*I knew you would. He knew it too.*”

Over the following days, I stayed in the nearest hamlet, lodging with an old woman whose son

spoke schoolbook French. I saw Mathilde twice. The first time, she spoke to me with an almost brutal lucidity about what she called *the passage*—a state in which one ceases to be only oneself. She spoke of it with the precision of a scientist and the wonder of a lover. My sister had never seemed so coherent. So certain.

The second time, she was crying silently in a recess of the tower, and when I approached, she stepped back.

“Don't touch me now,” she whispered. *“I'm not sure what would come back with you.”*

I did not understand that sentence until much later, one night when the wind against the shutters of my room sounded uncannily like a held breath on the other side of the wall.

The man who had welcomed me came to find me one evening in the little inn in the hamlet.

“You think we have harmed her,” he said. *“That's natural.”*

“And if I asked you to let her go?”

He made a vague gesture, almost a sad one.

“No one is keeping her here. We are not the ones holding Mathilde back. It is what she found within these walls, and nowhere else. You cannot tear someone away from one emptiness by offering them another.”

On the last evening, I returned to the church alone, climbing the frozen path beneath an almost full moon. The door was not locked—it never was. The nave was empty, the candles extinguished, but the air still held that soft metallic smell. The copper dragon on the wall seemed smaller in the darkness, almost ordinary.

Mathilde was sitting at the front, alone.

“I won't leave with you,” she said before I could open my mouth. *“But I wanted you to see that I'm all right.”*

She did not look all right. She looked vast and tired.

“Do you remember,” she continued, *“when we were little, and you hated sleeping with the window open because you were afraid of what might come in? I think I spent my entire life hoping that something would come in. And now that it has, I no longer know how to live with the window closed.”*

I stayed with her until dawn. I convinced her of nothing.

I left alone that morning. When I turned back one last time, I saw the cracked tower standing against a sky that was still gray, and for a fleeting moment I had the impression that the entire building was holding its breath, patiently waiting for someone else to push the door open.

I never saw Mathilde again.

Once or twice a year, I receive a postcard with no return address, sometimes postmarked in Romania, always bearing the same sentence:

I'm fine. Don't worry about the window.

Élise V. le 22 octobre 2013

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Translation : Keren Hazan